



JAMAICA CONSTABULARY FORCE

Earthquake Response Policy and Standard Operating Procedures

Title: JCF Earthquake Response Policy and Standard Operating Procedures	Identification Code: JCF/FW/PL/Ops/0012/2021
Effective Date: 2024-Nov-29	Pages: 14
Last Reviewed: 2024-Nov-22	Distribution: Force-wide
Revision version #: 1	Process Owner: Deputy Commissioner of Police Strategic Operations Portfolio
Rescinds: F.O. # 3830, dd. 2020-Oct-29	
Authors: PRDB & Strategic Operations Branch	Owner: JCF
Publication: F.O. # 3830, dd. 2020-Oct-29	Review: Biennially

Table of Contents

1.0	Introduction.....	3
2.0	Purpose.....	3
3.0	Scope.....	3
4.0	Abbreviations and Acronyms	3
5.0	Definitions.....	4
6.0	Responsibilities	4
7.0	Policy Statement	5
8.0	Standard Operating Procedures.....	5
8.1	Before an Earthquake	5
8.2	During an earthquake	6
8.3	After an earthquake	7
8.4	Establishment of an Earthquake Command Centre (ECC)	8
9.0	Legislative Authority/Guiding Principles	9
10.0	Roles and Functions	9
Appendix 1:	List of Stakeholders and Associated Roles	13
Appendix 2:	Job Description of JCF Safety Officer	13

1.0 Introduction

Jamaica's location, geological formation and other factors makes the island particularly susceptible to earthquakes. The first recorded earthquake in Jamaica dates back to 1687. Three subsequent earthquakes (1692, 1907 and 1993) not only proved the country's vulnerability to these events, but also highlight the associated devastating effects. Scientists today anticipate that the country may be on the brink of a major earthquake due to increased seismic activities and built up of stress along the fault line¹ which runs through the island.

The most common and damaging effects of an earthquake in inhabited areas is ground shaking. Ground shaking and movement along a fault cause an offset between rocks on opposite sides resulting in the damages such as breakage of power lines, pipelines, buildings, roads, bridges and other structures. Secondary earthquake hazards such as landslides and liquefaction (ground failure), tsunamis and fires also have potential devastating effects. The Jamaica Constabulary Force (JCF) is cognizant of its duties and responsibilities to preserve life and property and to restore and maintain order. These duties and responsibilities become even more critical in the aftermath of major disasters and their attendant to restore normalcy. Against this background, this policy and standard operating procedures is intended to position the organization to execute its role and function as a critical player in preparation for, and management of Major Earthquakes.

2.0 Purpose

This document outlines the JCF's policy and standard operating procedures for response in the event of a Major Earthquake in Jamaica. The purpose of this policy is to:

- 2.1 provide a guide to prepare members to take necessary actions before, during and after a Major Earthquake;
- 2.2 provide the framework for business continuity in the event of a Major Earthquake;
- 2.3 ensure the protection and preservation of life and property;
- 2.4 provide protection to critical infrastructure;
- 2.5 ensure the maintenance of public order;
- 2.6 outline protocols for search and rescue; and
- 2.7 provide framework to prevent/minimize further loss of life or damage to property resulting from secondary hazards.

3.0 Scope

This policy and standard operating procedures apply to all sworn and unsworn members of the JCF. It prescribes members' duties and responsibilities before, during and after a Major Earthquake.

4.0 Abbreviations and Acronyms

AECC Area Earthquake Command Centre

¹

A fracture along which the blocks of crust on either side have moved relative to one another parallel to the fracture

CCU	Constabulary Communication Network
ECC	Earthquake Command Centre
EEP	Emergency Evacuation Plan
IDDRR	International Day for Disaster Risk Reduction
IPROB	Inspectorate and Professional Standards Oversight Bureau
JCCF	Jamaica Combined Cadet Force
JCF	Jamaica Constabulary Force
JDF	Jamaica Defence Force
JFB	Jamaica Fire Brigade
MOHW	Ministry of Health & Wellness
NEOC	National Emergency Operations Centre
NWA	National Works Agency
ODPEM	Office of Disaster Preparedness and Emergency Management
PECC	Police Emergency Communications Centre
POC	Point of Contact
PRDB	Planning, Research and Development Branch
SAR	Search and Rescue
VIP	Very Important Person

5.0 Definitions

Assembly Point - An area where members and visitors gather in cases of emergency

Earthquake - Also known as tremor, is the shaking of the surface of the earth resulting from a sudden release of energy in the earth's lithosphere that creates seismic waves

Emergency Shelter - A designated place or area for temporarily housing due to disasters or other emergency circumstances.

Landslide - Movement of mass of rock, debris or earth down a slope under the direct influence of gravity

Major Earthquake - A tremor of magnitude $\geq 4.0^{22}$ or any that results in significant damage to major infrastructure; mass injury or loss of life; disruption to normal activities and or major flooding, tsunami, landslide, fire et cetera

Secondary Hazards - These are occurrences such as landslides, tsunamis, fire et cetera resulting from an earthquake

Tsunami - A type of secondary hazard involving an unusually large sea wave produced by a seaquake or undersea volcanic eruption

Vulnerable Area - An area identified to be susceptible to secondary hazards

6.0 Responsibilities

6.1 The DCP i/c Strategic Operations Portfolio shall have overall responsibility for the JCF's management and response to earthquakes and other disasters

² Earthquakes below a magnitude of 4.0 are considered minor (Earthquake Unit UWI)

- 6.2** The Area Commanders shall be responsible to manage the earthquake response activities within the respective area; exercise oversight of the Area Earthquake Command Centre; and provide operational support and all related resources within the Area
- 6.3** ACP i/c PSTEB shall be responsible for the management of emergency traffic contingencies and the enforcement of emergency public order and public safety strategies
- 6.4** The ACP i/c Special Operations shall be responsible for managing extraordinary occurrences such as riots, lootings and other public order issues arising from the disaster
- 6.5** Divisional Commanders shall be responsible for the management and coordination of emergency responses within their respective divisions
- 6.6** The SSP i/c CCU shall be responsible to develop and disseminate important internal and external information in the aftermath of an earthquake
- 6.7** The SP i/c PECC shall be responsible for the collection and dissemination of emergency warning and other information relating to secondary hazards
- 6.8** It shall be the responsibility of every member to comply with this policy and standard operating procedure.

7.0 Policy Statement

The management of earthquake response within the JCF shall incorporate best known practices world-wide as well as aligned to the Government of Jamaica (GOJ) strategy as outlined in the National Earthquake Response Plan³. The JCF recognizes that its mandate includes *inter alia*, saving lives, protecting properties, and promoting peace and good order. In order to discharge its mandate, it shall be the policy of the JCF to:

- i. collaborate with international, national and non-governmental agencies in order to ensure effective and coordinated response/support in the aftermath of a Major Earthquake;
- ii. create safe and effective environment for members in order to ensure business continuity in the aftermath of a Major Earthquake;
- iii. conduct and/or assist in search and rescue operations after a Major Earthquake; and
- iv. institute a culture that promotes mitigation and resilience by collaborating with stakeholders (see **Appendix 1**) with the aim of identifying vulnerable areas, evacuation routes and emergency shelters as well as developing SAR systems and protocols, and adopting best practices in earthquake management.

8.0 Standard Operating Procedures

8.1 Before an Earthquake

All Areas, Branches and Divisions shall adopt the following procedures prior to an Earthquake:

³ Revised draft 1999, Sub-plan of the National Disaster Plan, Office of Disaster Preparedness and Emergency Management (ODPEM)

- i. Develop and institute an Emergency Evacuation Plan (EEP) for each facility. Each EEP must have:
 - emergency exits clearly defined with appropriate signage;
 - emergency routes;
 - an Assembly Point clearly defined with appropriate signage;
 - an appointed Safety Officer (see Job Description at **Appendix 2**); and
 - graphic illustrations of the EEP prominently displayed.
- ii. Conduct annual earthquake drills.
- iii. Train members on specific roles and responsibilities as well as actions to taken by the general membership in the event of a Major Earthquake.
- iv. All police divisions/formations should have sufficient emergency supplies. The supplies must include but not limited to battery operated commercial radios, flashlights, first aid kits and stored water.
- v. Members should be familiar with the locations of lock-offs for water, gas and electricity, and the process involved in shutting them down.
- vi. All police divisions/formations/stations shall have a prominently displayed list of emergency contacts for personnel operating designated shelters, heavy duty machinery/equipment, healthcare services, public utilities and other emergency facilities/services.
- vii. Prior to major events that involve mass gathering (such as at stadium or arenas), briefing exercise should involve earthquake protocols.

8.2 During an earthquake

During an earthquake, members should adopt the following procedures:

8.2.1 If Indoor

- i. Do not run outside. Quickly move to a safe location such as under a desk, table, along an interior wall or near the structural strong points of the room.
- ii. Avoid taking cover near windows, large mirrors, hanging objects or heavy furniture/appliances.
- iii. If cover is taken under furniture, hold on to it and be prepared to move with it. Hold the position until the ground stops shaking and it is safe to move.
- iv. Do not use elevators.
- v. Follow directions of Safety Officer.
- vi. In some buildings, expect fire alarms and sprinklers to go off.

8.2.2 If on duty at crowded stadiums/arenas *et cetera*

- i. Implement the earthquake protocols as agreed during the briefing.
- ii. Do not rush for the exits.
- iii. Assume the role of Safety Officer, recognizing the duty to save lives including those of the VIPs.

8.2.3 If in an elevator

If power fails, elevators will stop and lights will go off. Be patient an emergency personnel will rescue you as soon as possible.

8.2.4 If trapped under debris

- i. Do not create any naked light.
- ii. Minimize unnecessary and excessive movements since this can result in exhaustion as well as further entrapment.
- iii. Cover mouth with handkerchief or clothing.
- iv. Tap on pipe or wall, or use a whistle so you can be heard and rescued. Shouting should only be a last resort, since it may result in inhalation of dust or other substance as well as exhaustion.

8.2.5 If outside

- i. Move to the designated Assembly Point or an open area out of the reach of possible falling objects.
- ii. Keep away from buildings, power lines and trees.
- iii. Follow directions of the Safety Officer.

8.2.6 If in a vehicle

- i. Pull over in a safe area.
- ii. Avoid stopping on or under bridges and overpasses, and under power lines, trees and large signs.
- iii. Stay with the vehicle.

8.3 After an earthquake

Members should adopt the following procedures after an earthquake:

- i. Expect aftershocks over the next hours or days. During SAR, caution should be taken to prevent further injury or deaths to victims and/or rescue team(s).
- ii. Check self and others for injuries.
- iii. Safety Officer must execute the facility's EEP. If the Safety Officer is not present or is unable to execute his/her function, the most senior person present at the location must assume command.
- iv. Do not evacuate automatically. Outdoor hazards may be greater than those indoor.
- v. Check for injured and/or trapped persons. Conduct SAR where necessary and summon for assistance if needed. Collaborate with relevant agencies where required.
- vi. Check for damage to buildings and other infrastructures. Check for hazardous conditions. If building is badly damaged, leave it until it has been inspected by a safety professional.
- vii. Dispatch patrols to make a rapid assessment of injuries, deaths, damage to critical infrastructures and other buildings.
- viii. Follow directions of emergency responders.
- ix. Do not re-enter building until told it is safe.
- x. If there is gas leakage, evacuate persons and open windows and doors. If it can be done safely, turn off the gas supply and summon fire department. Do not use any electrical appliances because a tiny spark could ignite the gas.

- xi. If power is out, unplug major appliances to prevent possible damage when the power returns. If sparks, frayed wires or hot insulation are detected, turn off electricity at the main fuse box or breaker. Avoid contact with water during this process
- xii. Monitor tsunami warning/watch and provide necessary update.
- xiii. Provide protection to agencies or emergency service providers where necessary.

8.4 Establishment of an Earthquake Command Centre (ECC)

8.4.1 In case of a Major Earthquake, an *Earthquake Command Centre* (ECC) shall be established at, and operates from Police Headquarters. This shall be the Primary ECC. Where the epicenter or location of major damage, injury or death is in Areas 1 – 3, the affected Area shall establish their *Area Earthquake Command Centre* (AECC). Police Headquarters ECC shall have command over the management of occurrences in Areas 4 and 5.

8.4.2 In the event that Police Headquarters is severely damaged and/or rendered inoperable, Harman Barracks shall be the Secondary ECC. The National Police College of Jamaica (NPCJ) shall be the Tertiary ECC should Harman Barracks becomes severely damaged and/or rendered inoperable.

8.4.3 Composition of ECC

The ECC will be commanded by an Assistant Commissioner of Police or a Senior Superintendent of Police with a rotating team of sub-officers as his/her support staff and may include members of the JDF, ODPEM and other agencies.

8.4.4 Resources of the ECC

The staffing of the ECC should include *inter alia*, Commander, Diarist, radio and telephone operators, information officer *et cetera*. Other resources should include monitors, maps, computers, communication media, base radios, telephones and standby generators.

8.4.5 Roles and Functions of the ECC

The roles and functions of the ECC shall include the following:

- i. Co-ordinate operational activities with the National Emergency Operations Centre (NEOC), the National Works Agency (NWA), the Jamaica Defence Force (JDF), the Jamaica Fire Brigade (JFB) and other government agencies engaged in implementing special measures.
- ii. Monitor and follow-up with Commanders of the respective Branches, Areas and Divisions to ensure that protocols are being enforced.
- iii. Take incoming calls, log incidents and give information where necessary.
- iv. Direct victims to Emergency Shelters and/or services.

- v. Manage and coordinate the acquisition of internal and external resources.
- vi. Serve as Point of Contact (POC) between the JCF and other stakeholders.
- vii. Monitor and give direction to the SAR teams.
- viii. Receive queries from all police formations and provide guidance and directions consistent with law, government policies and guidelines.
- ix. Liaise with the Assistant Commissioner of Police, Services Branch, Specialized Operations, Community Safety and Security Branch among others, to provide equipment and other supporting assets where necessary.
- x. Seek expert advice where necessary, on matters relating to medical, legal and other technical issues which may arise.
- xi. Submit reports and updates periodically or when required.
- xii. Provide verbal update to the Deputy Commissioner of Police i/c Strategic Operations Portfolio for the information of the Commissioner of Police and other Deputy Commissioners, as is necessary, on developing and/or related incident(s).
- xiii. Submit written reports to the DCP Strategic Operations Portfolio.

9.0 Legislative Authority/Guiding Principles

This policy is in keeping with provisions contained in the Constitution of Jamaica and the following legislations:

9.1 [Disaster Risk Management Act, 2015](#)

9.2 [Emergency Powers Act, 1920](#)

9.3 [Public Order Act, 1957](#)

9.4 [Constabulary Force Act, 1935](#)

10.0 Roles and Functions

10.1 Deputy Commissioner of Police i/c Strategic Operations Portfolio

The Deputy Commissioner of Police i/c Strategic Operations Portfolio shall have overall responsibility for disaster management in the organization. This role will include inter alia:

- i. Coordinating occupational safety training, certification/re-certification for Safety Officers through ODPEM or other recognized institution.
- ii. Assisting in building capacity and improving inter-agency collaboration.
- iii. Coordinating simulation and drill activities at the national level of JCF.

These activities shall be coordinated through the Areas/Divisional Operation Officers and the different Station Safety Officers.

10.2 Area Commander

The Area Commander shall:

- i. Establish an AECC if the epicenter or location of major damage, injury or death occurs in his/her Area.
- ii. Exercise oversight of the AECC; provide operational support and all related resources within the Area.

- iii. Forward daily reports to Deputy Commissioner of Police in charge of Operations and PECC.
- iv. Ensure that the list of Emergency Shelters is updated and that Divisional Commanders and support staff are made aware.
- v. Ensure that Divisional Officers and support staff are in compliance with the requirements contained in the Earthquake Response Policy and Standard Operating Procedures.

10.3 Divisional Commander

The Divisional Commander shall:

- i. Ensure that each facility in the Division has a robust and effective EEP.
- ii. Attend and participate in activities commemorating International Day for Disaster Risk Reduction (IDDRR), World Tsunami Day, Earthquake Awareness Week and other national events.
- iii. Collaborate with stakeholders to conduct earthquake simulations.
- iv. Submit quarterly returns of list of critical infrastructures, VIPs and Emergency Shelters.
- v. Submit quarterly returns of vulnerable areas in their Divisions.
- vi. Submit quarterly returns on the number of persons residing in vulnerable areas.
- vii. Submit quarterly returns of type and location of SAR assets, earth moving assets, floatable and submersible devices in their Divisions.
- viii. Attend Parish and/or Municipal Disaster Committee meetings.
- ix. Ensure that the requirements of the policy form a part of weekly lectures.
- x. Ensure stations/formations' heads conduct annual earthquake drills and submit report.
- xi. Identify persons with special needs (persons with all forms of disabilities) or who will require special assistance after an earthquake.
- xii. Develop a network of persons/business interests with special skills and resources to share, which includes a listing of tools, equipment, and materials to assist in SAR operations.
- xiii. In the aftermath of an earthquake, make an immediate assessment and seek medical attention for the injured.
- xiv. Collaborate with the emergency agencies to conduct SARs.
- xv. Develop a list of all persons reported missing or otherwise unaccounted for.
- xvi. Forward situation report to the PECC and Area Headquarters as soon as possible and by the fastest means available.
- xvii. Submit full report detailing:
 - information on persons killed, injured or missing;
 - name and details of persons in Emergency Shelters;
 - general condition of residents with regard to food, clothing, shelter, etc.;
 - damage to critical infrastructure, houses, factories and government property; and
 - blockage to major access points and thoroughfares.

10.4 Planning, Research and Development Branch (PRDB)

The Assistant Commissioner of Police in charge PRDB shall:

- i. Research and recommend best practices in earthquake preparedness, resilience and mitigation strategies.
- ii. Develop and maintain systems and protocols that will facilitate the collection, collation and dissemination of all data related to EEPs.
- iii. Conduct periodic review of the policy in accordance with legislative and/or operational changes and best practices.
- iv. Provide periodic strategic assessment and engage internal and external stakeholders on pertinent findings and report accordingly.

10.5 Station Commander/Sub-officer in charge

The Station Commander/Sub-officer in charge shall:

- i. Provide reports to the Divisional Commander on the status of their station area.
- ii. Ensure that there are designated Assembly Points
- iii. Ensure that the facility has a Safety Officer.
- iv. Ensure that Safety Officer executes his/her function in accordance with this Policy and their EEP.
- v. Identify persons in his/her station area who have special needs or may require special assistance in the event of an earthquake.
- vi. Keep updated list of emergency contacts for personnel operating designated shelters, heavy duty machinery/equipment, healthcare services, public utilities and other emergency facilities within his/her station area.
- vii. Provide all the returns as required by the Divisional Commander.

10.6 Safety Officer

The Safety Officer assigned to each facility shall:

- i. Execute their EEP.
- ii. Advise members on various safety-related matters.
- iii. Prepare educational seminars/webinars on a regular basis.
- iv. Identify and recommend areas for review in the JCF Earthquake Response Policy and SOPs.
- v. Implement safety training programmes.
- vi. Conduct risk assessment and outline mitigation strategies/activities.
- vii. Oversee workplace repair, installations and any other activity that could affect member's safety in the event of an earthquake.
- viii. Recommend repairs to unsafe and/or damaged facilities.

10.7 Telecommunications Division

The Superintendent of Police in charge Telecommunications shall in the aftermath of a Major Earthquake:

- i. Direct immediate action to repair any damaged equipment.
- ii. Re-establish communications as soon as is practicable.
- iii. Designate separate and/or dedicated communications channel for SARs and relief operations.

10.8 Police Emergency Communication Centre (PECC)

The Superintendent of Police in charge PECC shall in the aftermath of a Major Earthquake:

- i. Implement the necessary communication protocols.
- ii. Collect sensitive information and disseminate emergency warning and other information relating to secondary hazards such as tsunami warning/watch, land-slippages, trapped and/or injured personnel etc.
- iii. Direct SARs and relief operations to calls for service.

10.9 Specialized Operations

The Assistant Commissioner of Police in charge Specialized Operations shall in the aftermath of a Major Earthquake:

- i. Supply the necessary human resources, specialized equipment and heavy duty machinery to assist in clearing road/pathway blockage(s).
- ii. Liaise with NWA, JDF and other stakeholders in the event specialized equipment are needed.
- iii. Provide additional personnel or resources to combat extraordinary occurrences such as riots, lootings and other public order issues arising from the disaster.

10.10 Community, Security and Safety Branch (CSSB)

The Assistant Commissioner of Police in charge CSSB shall:

- i. Incorporate JCF Earthquake Response Policy and SOPs as part of its wider public sensitization programmes in schools, churches and other community based organizations.
- ii. Provide the appropriate welfare needs for members engaged in extraordinary duties in the aftermath of a Major Earthquake.

10.11 Public Safety and Traffic Enforcement Branch (PSTEB)

The Assistant Commissioner of Police in charge PSTEB shall:

- i. Develop Emergency Traffic Plans with detailed mapping of main routes and contingencies which may assist in transporting of persons and resources to and from affected areas.
- ii. Enforce public order and public safety strategies.

10.12 The Inspectorate and Professional Standards Oversight Bureau (IPROB)

The Inspector General in charge IPROB shall:

- i. Ensure that standards are maintained in the management of earthquake response in the JCF.
- ii. Hold personnel accountable for the implementation of the JCF Earthquake Response Policy and SOPs.

10.13 Constabulary Communication Unit (CCU)

The Senior Superintendent of Police in charge, CCU shall:

- i. Develop communication protocols to guide members' activities before, during and after an earthquake.
- ii. Disseminate important internal and external information in the aftermath of a Major Earthquake.

Appendix 1: List of Stakeholders and Associated Roles

Stakeholders	Summary Roles and Functions
Ministry of Health & Wellness	Coordination of health resources to aid affected persons
Jamaica Fire Brigade	SAR and other emergency responses
Office of the Disaster Preparedness and Emergency Management	Implementation of National Disaster Plan
Jamaica Defence Force	SAR and national security response
Ministry of Local Government (KSAC and Municipal Corporations)	Emergency shelter and care, monitor disaster zones, conduct Parish Disaster Committee Meetings
National Works Agency	Clear major roadway/provide heavy equipment
Jamaica Red Cross	Assist with welfare relief, search and rescue
Jamaica Urban Transit Company	Provide public transportation
St. Johns Ambulance Brigade	SAR and first aid
Department of Correctional Services	Management of Correctional/Remand facilities
Ministry of Education, Youth and Information	Coordinate access to schools used as emergency shelters
Jamaica Combined Cadet Force	Support and assist JDF with SAR
Jamaica Public Service	Management of light and power services
National Water Commission	Management of water supply
Earthquake Unit, UWI. Mona	Inform and collect information on earthquakes affecting Jamaica

Appendix 2: Job Description of JCF Safety Officer

Safety Officers of the Jamaica Constabulary Force (JCF) are responsible for planning, implementing and overseeing safety of JCF facilities. One of their main functions is to ensure compliance with the JCF's Earthquake Response Policy and Standard Operating Procedures.

JCF Safety Officer Job Purpose:

The JCF Safety Officers' purpose is to create, enact, and update the job safety programmes that encompass government health and safety regulations as well as the JCF's standards for safety in the workplace. They are required to train members on the importance of health and safety on the job.

1.1 Major Duties and Responsibilities:

- i. Execute the EEP.
- ii. Advise members on various safety-related matters.
- iii. Prepare educational seminars and webinars on a regular basis.
- iv. Identify and recommend areas for review in the JCF Earthquake Response Policy and SOPs.
- v. Implement safety training programmes.
- vi. Conduct risk assessment and outline mitigation strategies/activities.
- vii. Oversee workplace repairs, installations and any other work that could affect members' safety in the event of an earthquake.
- viii. Recommend repairs to unsafe and/or damaged facilities.

1.2 Requirements and Qualifications:

- i. Must be a sub-officer
- ii. Excellent knowledge of related legislations and procedures
- iii. Excellent knowledge of potentially hazardous materials or practices
- iv. Experience in producing reports
- v. Experience with writing policies and procedures for health and safety
- vi. Familiarity with conducting data analysis and reporting statistics
- vii. Working knowledge of safety management information system
- viii. Outstanding organizational skills
- ix. Critical thinking and problem-solving skills